expand China’s maritime trade and strengthen its naval power, a tradition which continued under the succeeding Ming dynasty up until 1435 CE when the country retreated, by choice and not by compulsion, behind its land frontiers for the next five centuries.

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The pastoral tribes inhabiting the Mongolian steppes were welded into a united fighting force under the charismatic and gifted military leader Genghis Khan, who in the thirteenth century successively demolished the Xi Xia and Jin dynasties in western and northern China. On the death of Genghis Khan in 1225, his chosen successor, his third son, Ogodei, greatly expanded the territories under Mongol rule, establishing the first Eurasian empire, stretching from the Pacific to the frontiers of Europe. During his twelve-year rule, parts of Russia, Georgia and Armenia came under Mongol rule, as did the eastern part of Persia. On his death in 1241, the succession was fiercely contested and remained unsettled until 1260, when the vast empire, from east to west, was divided among four khans.

The Mongolian homeland, China, Korea and Tibet fell under the sway of Kublai Khan. The Central Asian stretch from Lake Baikal and covering the entire Tarim Basin and Afghanistan came under the Chagatai line of the Genghis Khan family. The Chagatai Mongols made frequent incursions into northern and western India and even occupied parts of Punjab for a time. One of its rulers, Duwa Khan, launched repeated expeditions into north India, then under the Delhi Sultanate (1206–1526), but was decisively defeated by Allaudin Khilji in 1305. There were frequent clashes between the Mongol rulers in China and the Chagatai Mongols over control of the caravan routes of Central Asia.

The Ilkhanid branch of the Mongols ruled the West Asian region, including Persia, eventually including the territory formerly under the Abbasid caliphate. Baghdad, the Abbasid capital, fell to the Ilkhanids in 1258.

The fourth branch of the Mongols comprised the so-called ‘Golden Hordes’ that ruled over much of Russia.